

MANHWA

Solo Leveling

★★★★☆ | The background of Solo Leveling revolves around hunters, who are awakened people in our world that gain a significant ascension in strength and certain abilities to combat monsters that infiltrate our dimension via space warping holes known as Gates. These gates connect the real world to the realm of magic and monsters and are a gateway to certain dungeons which (as you guessed) house monsters packing their bags to raid and massacre the human world.

Other than the background, what we have here is a vividly drawn, action packed story of an underdog E-rank hunter, Sung Jin Woo, (the one entitled "world's weakest" in fact), who under-



goes a tragic incident with a near-death experience which results in him coming out the other end as an OP protagonist. But wait, we have heard about such things umpteen times, so what does Solo Leveling do different to stand out from the other stories of similar kind?

The answer is the progression of this manhwa (manhwa = general Korean term for comics). Straight out of the story,

the protagonist doesn't acquire what you will call true limitless power (*glances at OPM*). Instead, he is greeted with a strange game-like system, to gradually gain strength and abilities as he levels up by defeating monsters; which assists him in his ordeals and thus justifying the latter part of the title. This queer system is only visible to him, integrated with all the objects and characters in the world, giving him more items or skills as he defeats monsters. As we progress further into the story, the character undergoes a significant change in both his personality as well as abilities, facing much potent enemies and harder challenges. **[Spoiler Alert]** Soon after hitting higher levels, he gains abilities more centric towards his special class. This includes the ability to turn most of his potential enemies, that he defeated, into a part of his shadow army. All this makes him pretty much undefeatable.

—Nayan Panda

MOVIE

Free Guy

★★★★☆ | At first glance, Free Guy looks like a movie that is meant to appeal specifically to the gamer crowd, but that's really not the case. You can enjoy the movie just fine even with zero background knowledge about games. The movie does a decent job of explaining things to you, so you can get through the movie without any issues. However, if you do happen to have a gamer background and have at least some knowledge about gaming culture you will enjoy the movie a lot more. There's plenty of references and easter eggs to be found.

Coming to the gist of the movie, Guy is an NPC. An NPC in the game Free City who thinks everything is just great. Not good mind you, great! If you have already watched the movie you'll get that reference, or you will get the reference once you do watch the movie. He is a banker who works at one of the banks in Free City. His best friend, Buddy, is a security



guard, he always drinks the exact same coffee from the exact same barista at the exact same time every single day. And always wears the exact same blue shirt and khaki pants. All because he's an NPC and he's programmed to behave this way. Meanwhile, you've got the "sunglass-wearing heroes" wreaking havoc around Free City, robbing banks, murdering innocent NPCs and pretty much doing what they please.

The sunglass-wearing heroes in this case are the players, people who are playing the MMORPG Free City. To Guy, who's programmed to think they're heroes, what they're doing is completely normal, and Free City is a great place to live. If you're an NPC though, it's really not. However, Guy is slightly different from the other NPCs. While all of the NPCs in the game use very advanced AI, they're still shackled by their programming. Guy, however, is programmed slightly differently and capable of something none of the other NPCs are – falling in love. Yep, it's pretty cliché but that's how it is. This leads to Guy breaking out of his programmed daily routine and stealing one of the player's sunglasses, which is basically their in-game HUD. This results in Guy seeing Free City the way players do and he begins his quest to find his true love.

Overall, we found Free Guy to be pretty enjoyable with all of its references and easter eggs. Ryan Reynolds carries the show pretty hard and there are guest appearances from tons of popular Twitch and YouTube gaming streamers. Definitely worth a watch.

—Manish Rajesh